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Gas Prices Are Americans' Top Concern in Iran War

Public is split on whether the U.S. is doing enough to avoid civilian casualties

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RECOMMENDED CITATION

Pew Research Center, April 2026, "Gas Prices Are Americans' Top Concern in Iran War"

Gas Prices Are Americans' Top Concern in Iran War

Public is split on whether the U.S. is doing enough to avoid civilian casualties

Nearly six weeks into the U.S. military campaign against Iran, a new Pew Research Center survey finds that higher gas prices are the outcome that concerns Americans the most. But [majorities also worry](#) about the United States sending ground troops into Iran, large numbers of military casualties, terrorist attacks on U.S. soil, and the war expanding outside the Middle East.

The survey was conducted March 23-29 among 3,507 U.S. adults.

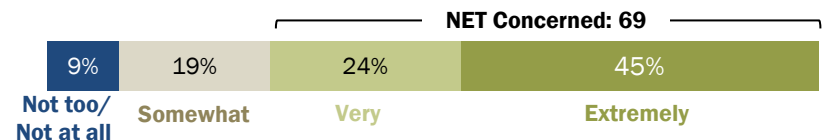
Conduct of the war

Americans are closely divided on whether the U.S. is doing enough to prevent civilian casualties in the Iran war: 41% say it's doing enough, while 45% say the opposite; 13% are not sure.

Most Republicans and Republican-leaning independents say the U.S. is *doing enough* to prevent civilian casualties (65%), while a similar share of Democrats and Democratic leaners (68%) say it is not. But there is broad agreement among all adults that Iran itself is not doing enough to prevent civilian casualties (69%).

How Americans view key aspects of the Iran war

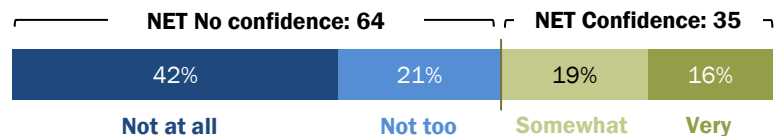
% who say, thinking about the U.S. military action against Iran, they are ___ concerned about **higher gas and fuel prices**



% who say the U.S. is ___ to **avoid civilian casualties** in the U.S. military action against Iran



% who say they are ___ confident that Donald Trump can make good decisions when it comes to **U.S. policy toward Iran**



Note: Those who said "Not sure" or did not answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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Americans also express little faith in President Donald Trump's ability to make good decisions when it comes to Iran: 35% are confident in his policymaking in this area, while 64% are not.

Around two-thirds of Republicans (66%) are confident, compared with fewer than one-in-ten Democrats (7%).

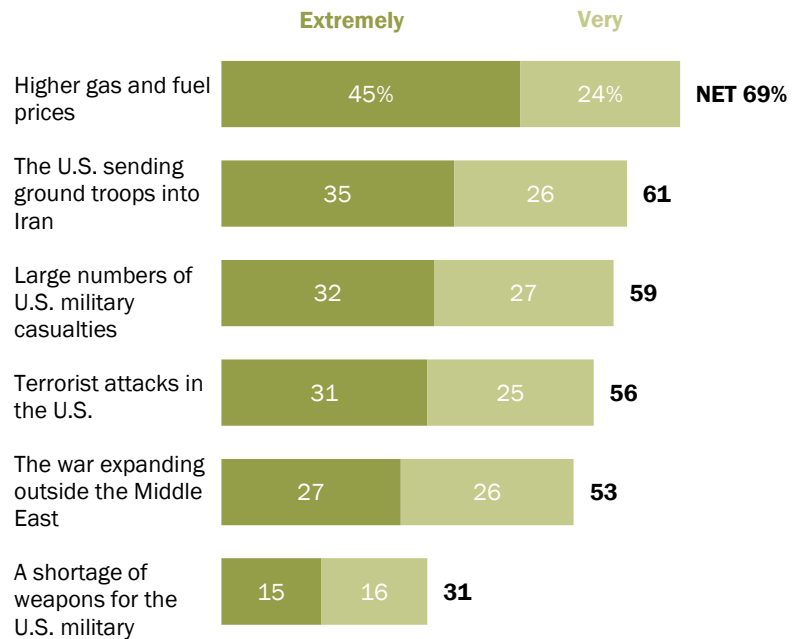
Read more on confidence in Trump's ability to handle various foreign policy issues.

How might the war affect Iran?

Americans are equally divided on whether U.S. military action will make Iran's development of a nuclear weapon more likely (27%), less likely (27%) or about as likely as before (29%), while another 16% are not sure. Younger Americans and Democrats are more likely than older adults and Republicans to say U.S. military action will *increase* the likelihood of Iran obtaining a nuclear weapon.

About 7 in 10 Americans are concerned about higher gas prices resulting from military action against Iran

% who say, thinking about the U.S. military action against Iran, they are _____ concerned about each of the following



Note: Those who said "Not sure" or did not answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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Americans also have differing views about the ultimate fate of Iran after the conflict ends. More say the Iranian people will be worse off (36%) than say they will be better off (25%), while 16% believe they will be about as well off as before and 21% are not sure.

Additionally, most Americans (77%) say the U.S. military action against Iran is important to them personally, including 48% who say it is *very* important to them. Majorities of Republicans (81%) and Democrats (76%) alike hold this view.

Do Americans think Trump can make good decisions about Iran?

Confidence in Trump's ability to make good decisions about U.S. policy toward Iran has declined among both Republicans and Democrats.

In the latest survey, 35% of Americans are very or somewhat confident in Trump's policymaking in this area, while 64% are not too or not at all confident.

Confidence in Trump's dealings with Iran is down 12 percentage points since 2024, when he was running for a second presidential term. And it has declined by 9 points since August 2025.

Among Republicans, there has been an 18-point decline in confidence since 2024 and a 12-point drop since 2025. Confidence among Democrats has decreased from 14% in 2025 to 7% today.

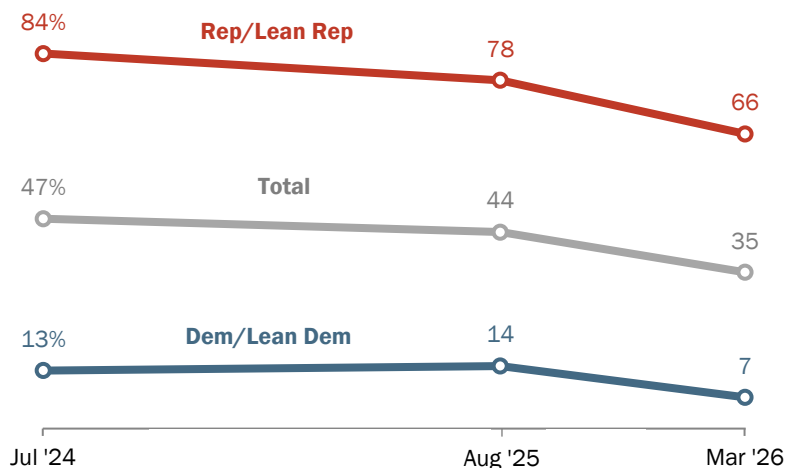
There is also a stark age divide among Republicans.

The youngest Republicans (ages 18 to 29) are divided: 46% are confident in Trump's policymaking toward Iran, while 53% are not. But Republicans ages 65 and older are overwhelmingly confident (80%) in Trump's ability to make good decisions in this area.

Republicans who are concerned about the higher gas prices as a result of the war are also less likely to have confidence in Trump's policymaking on Iran. Among Republicans who are extremely or very concerned about gas prices increasing, 56% have confidence in him, while 44% do not.

Declining confidence in Trump's ability to make good policy decisions about Iran

% who say they are **very/somewhat confident** that Donald Trump can make good decisions when it comes to U.S. policy toward Iran, by party



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown. In previous surveys, the question read "wise decisions" instead of "good decisions." In 2024, we asked about candidate Trump and issues he "may face next year."

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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Among Republicans who are *not* concerned about gas prices increasing, 86% have confidence in Trump to make good policy decisions.

What are Americans' concerns about the Iran war?

About seven-in-ten Americans (69%) are concerned about higher gas and fuel prices as a result of the U.S. military action against Iran, including 45% who are *extremely* concerned. Of the potential outcomes we asked about, this one worries Americans most.

Majorities also are concerned about the U.S. sending ground troops into Iran, large numbers of military casualties, terrorist attacks in the U.S., and expansion of the war into countries outside the Middle East.

Fewer Americans (31%) are concerned about a shortage of weapons for the U.S. military.

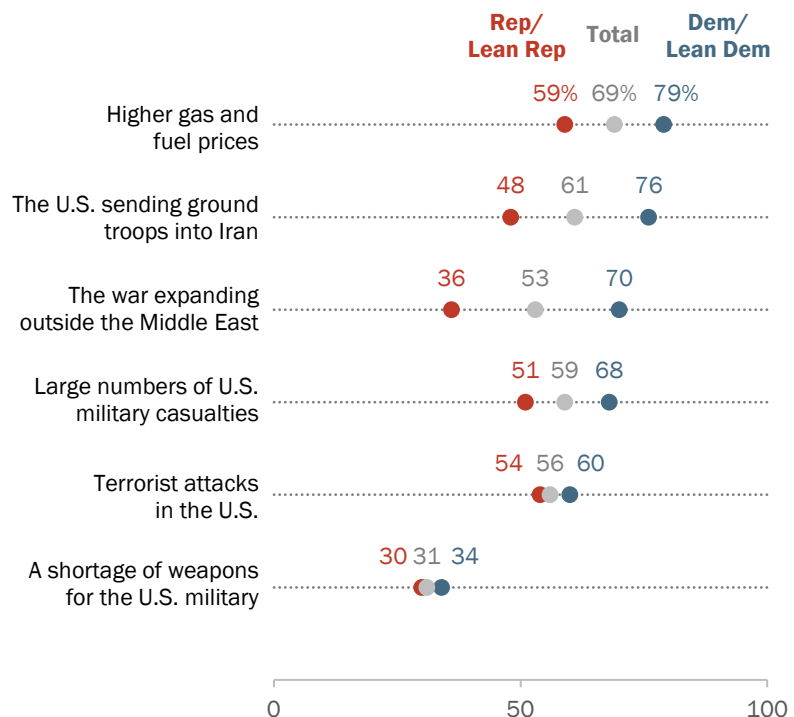
Levels of concern also differ by party. Still, most Democrats (79%) and Republicans (59%) are worried about higher gas prices as a result of the Iran war.

However, Democrats are about twice as concerned as Republicans about the conflict expanding outside the Middle East.

Another [Pew Research Center survey](#) conducted in March found that 68% of Democrats think the war will continue for six months or longer, while 58% of Republicans expect the war to end within the next six months.

Majorities in both parties are concerned the Iran war could lead to higher gas prices and terrorist attacks

% who say, thinking about the U.S. military action against Iran, they are *extremely/very* concerned about each of the following, by party



Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.
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Related: [*Americans Broadly Disapprove of U.S. Military Action in Iran*](#)

Are both sides doing enough to avoid civilian casualties?

Majorities of Americans in both parties say Iran is not doing enough to avoid civilian casualties in the war.

But the public is more divided on the U.S., though slightly more say it is *not* doing enough to prevent civilian casualties (45%) than say it is doing enough (41%).

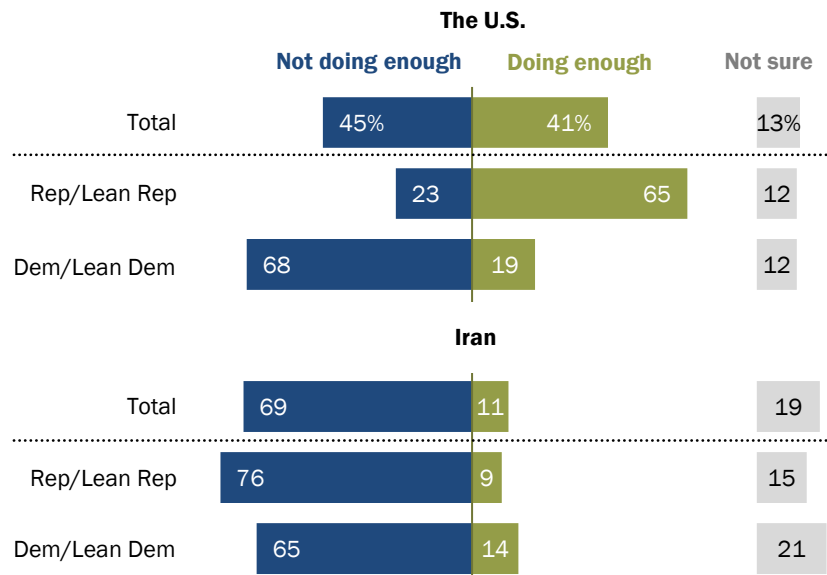
Around two-thirds of Democrats (68%) say the U.S. is not doing enough to avoid civilian casualties, compared with 23% of Republicans.

Younger Republicans are more likely than older Republicans to say that the U.S. is not doing enough to avoid civilian casualties. Around one-third of Republicans ages 18 to 29 (35%) say this is the case, compared with 13% of those ages 65 and older.

Among Democrats, there are no significant age differences on this question.

Americans tend to say Iran is not doing enough to avoid civilian casualties but are divided on the U.S.

% who say, thinking about the U.S. military action and Iran's military response, each of the following countries is ___ to avoid civilian casualties



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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What are the projected outcomes of the war?

Americans are evenly divided on whether U.S. military action will hinder Iran's ability to develop a nuclear weapon. But more predict the conflict will leave the Iranian people worse off, rather than better off, in the long run. Younger Americans and Democrats tend to be more skeptical of the outcomes of military action.

Likelihood of Iran developing a nuclear weapon

There are no real differences in the shares of Americans who say Iran will be more likely (27%), less likely (27%) or about as likely as before (29%) to develop a nuclear weapon.

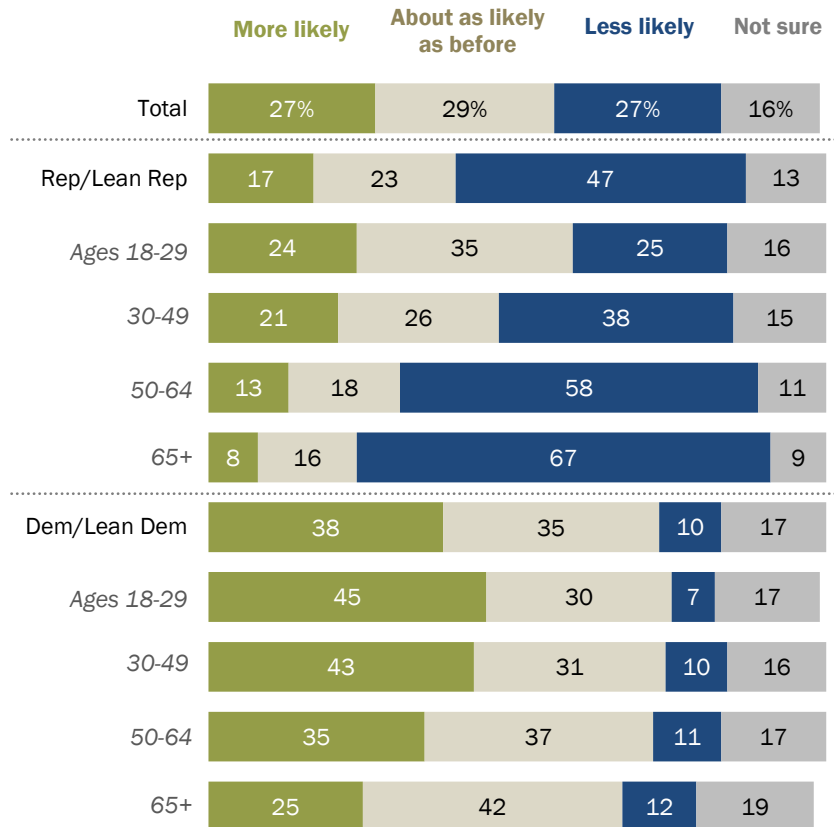
Republicans are nearly five times more likely than Democrats to say this will be less likely in the long run (47% vs. 10%). In contrast, 17% of Republicans and 38% of Democrats expect Iran will be *more* likely to develop a nuclear weapon than before.

Republicans ages 65 and older are significantly more likely than those ages 18 to 29 to say Iran will be less likely to develop a nuclear weapon (67% vs. 25%).

Democrats ages 18 to 29 are more likely than those ages 65 and older to say this is *more* likely (45% vs. 25%).

Older and younger Republicans diverge on whether military action will make Iranian nuclear capability less likely

% who say that in the long run, U.S. military action against Iran will make Iran's development of a nuclear weapon ...



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown.

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Impact of the conflict on the Iranian people

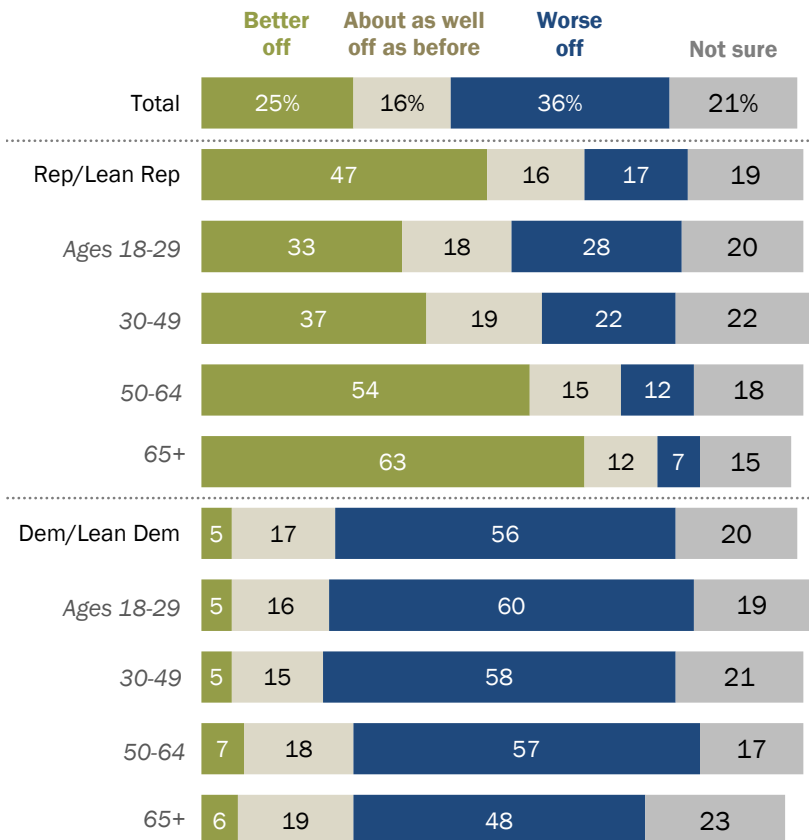
When it comes to the ultimate outcome of U.S. military action, 36% of Americans say that the Iranian people will be worse off. A quarter say the Iranian people will be better off, and 16% expect no change.

Just under half of Republicans (47%) expect the Iranian people to be better off as a result of U.S. military action, while just 5% of Democrats agree. A majority of Democrats (56%) expect the Iranian people to be worse off, as do 17% of Republicans.

Again, there are age differences within each party, but the contrast is much more stark among Republicans: Around six-in-ten Republicans ages 65 and older (63%) say the Iranian people will be better off in the long run, compared with 33% of those ages 18 to 29.

More Americans predict the Iranian people will be worse off than better off due to U.S. military action

% who say that in the long run, U.S. military action against Iran will make the Iranian people ...



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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Do Americans think Trump can make good decisions about various foreign policy issues?

A new Pew Research Center survey conducted March 23-29 finds that majorities of Americans express little or no confidence in President Donald Trump's handling of various foreign policy issues.

The survey asked about his decision-making in 12 foreign policy areas, including bilateral relations with several countries, trade and international military conflicts.

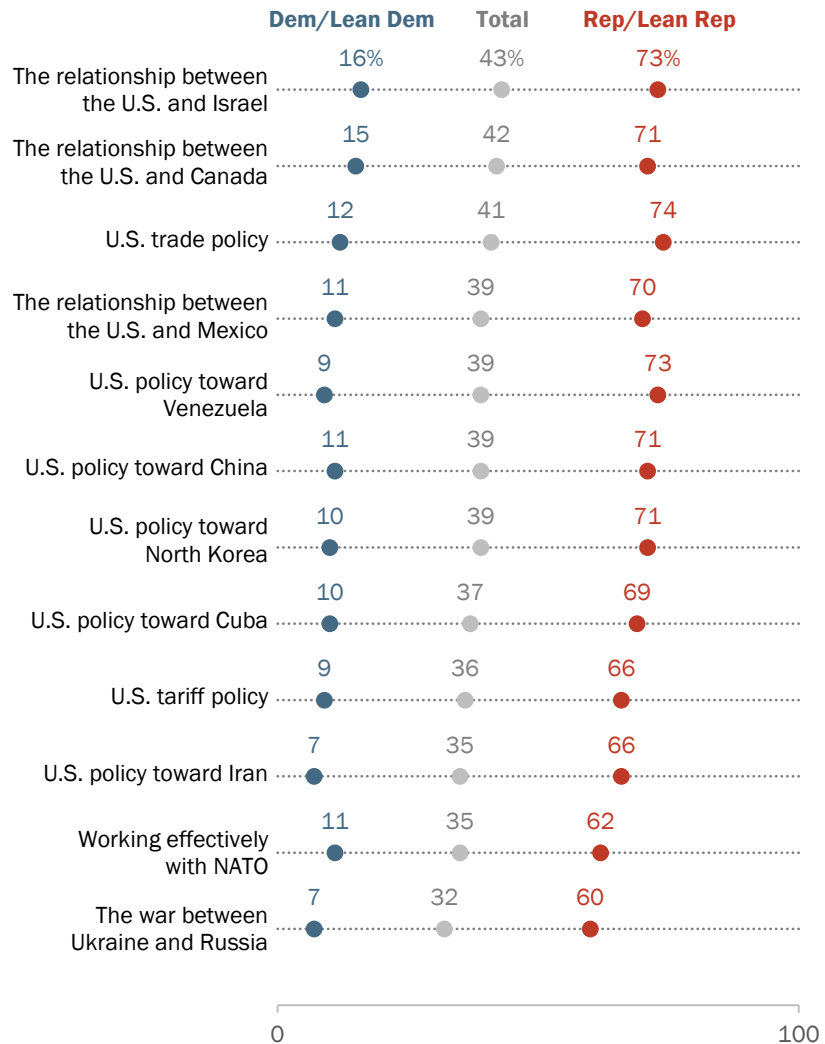
There is no issue on which a majority express confidence in Trump, but he garners more support in some areas than others. For example, 43% of Americans are very or somewhat confident in his handling of U.S.-Israel relations, compared with 32% who have confidence in him to make good decisions about the Russia-Ukraine war.

There are wide and persistent partisan gaps on these questions.

Among Republicans and independents who lean toward

Confidence in Trump's foreign policy decisions

% who say they are **very/somewhat confident** that Donald Trump can make good decisions when it comes to each of the following, by party



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown.

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

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the Republican party, confidence in Trump to make good policy decisions ranges from 74% on trade policy to 60% on the Russia-Ukraine war.

Democrats and Democratic leaners peak at 16% confidence on Trump's handling of U.S.-Israel relations. But that shrinks to just 7% confidence on U.S. policy toward Iran and the Russia-Ukraine war.

On every issue in the survey, Republicans ages 50 and older are more confident than those ages 18 to 49. For instance, older Republicans are 27 percentage points more confident than younger ones when it comes to Trump's handling of U.S.-Israel relations (87% vs. 60%).

On some of these issues, there has been a noticeable downward trend in confidence over time.

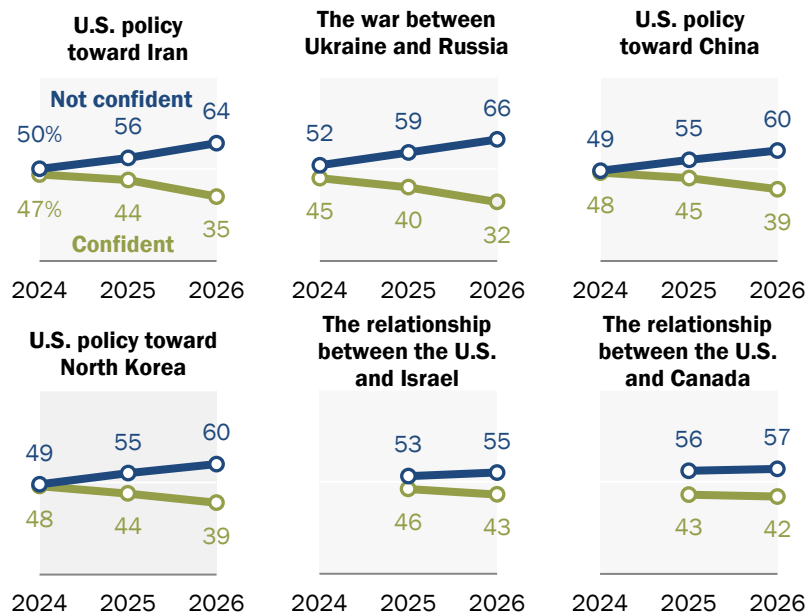
For example, confidence in Trump's ability to make good decisions on the Russia-Ukraine war was at 45% in 2024, during his campaign for a second presidential term. But that share fell to 40% in 2025 and stands at 32% today.

Confidence in Trump's ability to make good policy decisions toward Iran, China and North Korea has also declined.

Views on Trump's handling of U.S. relations with Israel and Canada have not change since 2025. But confidence is down on policy toward Venezuela since this past January (44% then vs. 39% today).

Confidence in Trump's ability to make good decisions on certain foreign policy issues is falling

% who say they are ___ that Donald Trump can make good decisions when it comes to each of the following



Note: Those who did not answer are not shown. In previous surveys, the question read "wise decisions" instead of "good decisions." In 2024, we asked about presidential candidate Trump and issues he "may face next year."

Source: Survey of U.S. adults conducted March 23-29, 2026.

"Do Americans think Trump can make good decisions about various foreign policy issues?"

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